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Heidegger, Religion, and the Transience of Digital Memory

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The time of the world's night is the destitute time, because it becomes ever more destitute. It has already grown so destitute, it can no longer discern the default of God as a default.

' Martin Heidegger

We do indeed say something about it, but we certainly do not speak it, and we have neither knowledge or thought of it. But if we do not have it in knowledge, do we not have it at all? But we have it in such a way that we speak about it, but do not speak it. For we say what it is not, but we do not say what it is: so that we speak about it from what comes after it.

' Plotinus, Ennead V

Not just in commerce but in the world of ideas too our age is putting on a veritable clearance sale. Everything can be had so dirt cheap that one begins to wonder whether in the end anyone will want to make a bid.

' Søren Kierkegaard

Theology is not lost, but it does not know where it is.^[^1] As philosophical theology finds itself searching for legitimation and direction in its continued inquiries ' what Carl A. Raschke has suggested is the move from "theology to theory"^[^2] ' it is forced to undertake a course which takes seriously Mark C. Taylor's "deconstructed theology," one that grasps: the death of God; the disappearance of the subject; the end of history; and the closure of the book, four critical deaths.¹ It is in this manner that *thinking about religion* both transgresses and restores its demise, its own 'passing on.'^[^4] And woven through the epigraphs by Heidegger, Plotinus, and Kierkegaard, a certain attitude toward these deaths and their age is formed, an attitude characterized by a revival of the notion or conception of memory. This memory is what I would like to suggest is pivotal to any re-thinking or re-formulation of thinking (about) religion and, while it perhaps must be undertaken in new ways, it is both a persistent inheritance of theology and an integral aspect of theory.

... the latest lithesome discovery of John Casablancas, the founder of Elite Model Management, which shaped the careers of Cindy Crawford and Naomi Campbell. Webbie exists only in cyberspace, the creation of a Swedish animator named Steven St'hlberg, but that didn't hinder her from posing for a feature in *Details* in October, 1999, and a new Nokia phone advertising campaign in Latin America. Most recently, Webbie was signed by Sony Music Latin America to join a Spice Girls-style virtual band. ^[^6]

¹Heidegger is speaking of a concern for the world's destitution, that which is marked by an absence of the gods and the need for remembrance of all that has transacted to this point in order to regain an ability to discern. Destitution or loss thus folds upon itself many times over, increasing the distance between the world and its own discernment, a sort of self-distancing or distraction. Plotinus writes of the necessity to recall that having and knowing do not necessarily connote speaking in a direct manner, that speaking after or about is the only choice for religious speech. And lastly, Kierkegaard reminds, in this familiar introduction to *Fear and Trembling*, how certain ideas can be made pedestrian and therefore cheapened, devoid of an attached or earned sense of value, and therefore calls for a memory of the labor with which thought comes. The challenge, therefore, in walking through and between these thoughts, is not only how to avoid not speaking but also how to root thinking in the memory of its own becoming. Memory then, and its corollary, forgetfulness, is the focus of this paper. To further explain this sort of perceiving, thinking, and remembering, the vital role of memory in thinking religion today must be located and described.

8. Webbie Tookay and other digital creations present a new class of citizens known as “Super Virtual Models,” valued for their effortless figures, minimal diets, and the ability to be in many places at once. Ms. Tookay is even represented by Illusion2k, a modeling agency run by Casablancas for virtual models. Interestingly, she is inspired not by an actual individual, but by the cult heroine Lara Croft, who starred in the *Tomb Raider* video games series and who is currently portrayed by Angelina Jolie in the current film based on the video game.[⁷] Adds Mr. Casablancas, “sometimes I wish all models were virtual.”[⁸]

The world's night is spreading its darkness. The era is defined by the god's failure to arrive, by the 'default of God,' ... [which means that] no god any longer gathers men and things unto himself, visibly and unequivocally, and by such gathering disposes the world's history and man's sojourn in it. ...²

Poets are the mortals who, singing earnestly of the wine-god, sense the trace of the fugitive gods, stay on the gods' tracks, and so trace for their kindred mortals the way toward the turning. ' This is why the poet in the time of the world's night utters the holy.³

What is meant by the talk about the end of philosophy (*Ende der Philosophie*)? We understand the end of something all too easily in the negative sense as a mere stopping, as the lack of continuation, perhaps even as decline and impotence. In contrast, what we say about the end of philosophy means the completion of metaphysics (*die Vollendung der Metaphysik*).[¹⁵]

*For the wanderer doesn't bring a handful of that
unutterable earth from the mountainside down to the valley,
but only some word he's earned, a pure word, the yellow
and blue gentian. Maybe we're here only to say: house,
bridge, well, gate, jug, olive tree, window '*

²The creation of Webbie Tookay signifies a passage, but more importantly it highlights the desire of the *new* to convince us of its own originality, its freedom from the *old* and therefore its radical innovation. Put another way, there is a tendency in present thinking to disconnect former modes of thought from current. Intellectual history is thus largely and intentionally forgotten. In the case of Ms. Tookay, the recognition of this passage or transformation suggests that while it is easy to think that Mr. St'hlberg created her *ex nihilo*, he in fact did not form her in a void, detached from the history of image-creation and manipulation. And yet even *this* recognition will be quickly forgotten (a quality of newspaper articles is that they are easily forgotten). The *technique* left behind by his innovation is that of traditional photography of “real-world” materiality (in that the digital imagery aims at being indistinguishable from photography); but the *idea* forgotten, cancelled, or muted with the advent of Ms. Tookay is that images are formed and re-formed by choice and for reasons specific to and rooted in the history of the image. The visual arts have already been quite successful in convincing their audience to forget that in fact the photograph is never really real ' that its contrivance and re-production are its essential characteristics ' and so it is consumed in an absent-minded or uncritical manner. Photography wishes it to be forgotten that photos are in fact *made*. In the age of the digital reproduction of the work of art, the emphasis is always away from notions of source or *episteme* and towards the wonder of and functionality of a work itself, away from the past and toward the very present. This age does not ask how the image came to be or what stratagems it has undergone in its arrival, but rather valorizes the “truer” content of the image as consumed.

³The forgetfulness of modern Western culture is a negation, but more precisely an absent-minded or forgetful negation, wherein the loss of the former is masked by the latter. This sort of forgetfulness is one that inhibits us from remembering that things were not always this way; instead, it pushes away from asking authentic questions of source, history, or connectedness. There will perhaps be a day in the not-so-distant future when the use of virtual models for film and media will be both technically marvelous and commonplace, to the point that it will be trivial to consider. That time will be marked by an attitude dismissive of any remembrance of the transformation now taking place: of asking the question “when (and how) did this change come about?”

at most, pillar, tower . . . but to say them, remember,
oh, to say them in a way that the things themselves
never dreamed of existing so intensely. [^18]

To our grandparents, a “house,” a “well,” a familiar steeple, even their own clothes, their cloak *still* meant infinitely more, were infinitely more intimate’almost everything a vessel in which they found something human already there, and added to its human store. Now there are intruding, from America, empty indifferent things, sham things, *dummies of life* A house, as the Americans understand it, an American apple or a winestock from over there, have *nothing* in common with the house, the fruit, the grape into which the hope and thoughtfulness of our forefathers had entered⁴

I’ll go along with the charade
Until I can think my way out.
I know it was all a big joke
Whatever it was about.
Someday maybe
I’ll remember to forget.⁵

We [pragmatists] simply refuse to talk in a certain way, the Platonic way. The views we hope to persuade people to accept cannot be stated in Platonic terminology. So our efforts at persuasion must take the form of gradual inculcation of new ways of speaking, rather than of straightforward argument within old ways of speaking.[^22]

Notes

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⁴To speak of remembrance is also to speak of a history of philosophical thought: of Derrida’s *cl’ture* (closure), of Heidegger’s *Vollendung* (completion), and of Hegel’s *Aufhebung* (sublation), the double-cancellation that always leaves a gift or trace behind. Crucial to articulating any remembrance of the trace is Heidegger’s notion (subsequently reiterated by Derrida[^14]) of *’berwindung der Metaphysik*, the “overcoming of metaphysics,” presented in “The End of Philosophy and the Task of Thinking”:

⁵To understand this overcoming is not simply to think it done away with, as many today flatten Postmodernity into the idea that metaphysics, Platonism, theology, or meta-narratives have simply been done away with: that their efficacy as models for thought is passed/past. Rather, overcoming is never a cessation, but always a closure. Simon Critchley, in a section of *The Ethics of Deconstruction* entitled “The Problem of Closure in Derrida,” describes this distinction well, noting that Heidegger (and Derrida) “does not understand the end of philosophy as a full stop, or conclusion, to the metaphysical tradition; instead, it is necessary to think *das Ende* in terms of *die Vollendung*, as a completion, or fulfillment, of metaphysics.”[^16] It is not a perfection or finality, but a completion or closure (*cl’ture*) that has left a taste in the mouth of thought.[^17] This brings to mind the cancellation or conversion to which Rilke refers in his ninth elegy:

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